of Myanmar into its own geopolitical goals.[77] And so long as isolationism has not got in the way of either the acquisition of weaponry or the making of money, the regime was keen to retain this foreign policy stance.

However, post-2008 Myanmar has had to balance external pressures from China and the US about its North Korean ally. To date, the regime has proved unwilling to break from North Korea despite US pressure, for example Defense Secretary Chuck Hagel's demand in 2015 that 'it's important that Myanmar sever ties with North Korea'.[78]

The military remains obsessed by fears of invasion.[79] In the early years after independence the largest fear was of China, but the regime regards almost all external powers as potential threats. After the repression of the pro-democracy movement in 1988, a fear of a new enemy emerged as the decision to ignore the 1990 elections brought the regime into conflict with the EU and the US, which both imposed sanctions. This intensified in the early years of the Bush presidency when Burma was publicly linked with regimes such as North Korea, Iran, Belarus and Zimbabwe as 'outposts of tyranny'.[80]

To the generals, this diplomatic isolation was linked to moves to have the UN Security Council declare Burma a threat to regional security, international praise for Aung San Suu Kyi and open support for other opposition groups. The return to public unrest in the form of the 2007 Saffron Revolution was seen by the generals as being the result of foreign intervention (and linked to fears about the various US-inspired 'colour' revolutions in former Soviet republics).[81] Their paranoia about invasion reached new heights when the US, Britain and France sent warships to the area to help in the aftermath of Cyclone Nargis. Such fears were stoked by the French, in particular, stressing that the regime was a barrier to the delivery of aid and that military force might be needed to ensure that relief reached those suffering in Myanmar.[82]

The overall defensive and suspicious mindset of the military to the outside world has been a regular part of their response to criticism of the persecution of the Rohingyas. They use nationalism in fused with Buddhism to reject external influences and solidify military rule. In a multi-ethnic state, as we saw earlier, the army sees itself as the only body that captures the true spirit of the nation: